

Bond the Hot Dog. 50 million fry bounty. The poster was loosely taped to the street light, flapping in the wind, crinkled at the edges. Bond walked down the alley, puddles scattering water with every step. The rain had just stopped and all that was left was the cold, dark night. Bond's bun wrapped around him was the only thing keeping him warm as he trudged back to his hideout. He had just come back from planning his biggest heist yet: The Central Fry Bank. Inside, 900 million fries lay, waiting for Bond to come and take them. Bond smiled as he stepped: he was so close to achieving his lifelong goal of being the most wanted food in all of the world. His obsession had started in 5th grade out of fear. Bond had been bullied every day in school, unable to defend himself. His bullies would suffocate him in condiments, rip parts of his bun off, and boil him in scalding hot water. From the day he left that school, he swore to be the most feared food in all of the world and never be messed with again.

Bond walked down alleys with his head held high. He loved the rain. Everyone feared it: went indoors, tried to hide under umbrellas. Rain struck when it wanted. It could turn into a storm or a tsunami. Droplets peppered down all around him, sliding down his side in a silky manner. His hideout was just ahead of him now: an unassuming tent at the edge of the road. It almost blended into the background, the grey and black accents matching the rain against the concrete. He crouched down and unzipped the front slowly. Grunting as he took off his shoes, he slowly crawled into the tent. The tent was sparse: a pizza box, sleeping bag, pillow, ground pad, flashlight, and a few other random supplies. Bond slowly sat down on the floor, feeling the cold concrete under the tent. Rain pelted the top, drumming a beat to some imaginary song. Bond looked around, spotting the pizza box. His eyes lit up as he picked out a slice. He loved deep dish pizza. His mom had made it for him on Fridays after school, and it had been a reminder that someone still loved him. Now he bought it every week to remind him of her, ever since she had

passed away. The slice was a cold, dense wedge, heavy as a brick, with the cheese solidified into a thick, rubbery white layer that had welded itself to the chunky, ruby tomato sauce. His smile faded as he stared at it. He left it in the pizza box, closed it, and planned to throw it out tomorrow.

Bond slipped into his sleeping bag, rubbing his hands against his chest, trying to warm up. He stared up at the roof of the tent, watching it bend inward and snap back with each gust of wind. He lay there, beginning to think. Tomorrow was the biggest day of his life. He thought it only made sense to reflect beforehand. He thought about his first job: a small condiment stand on the corner of 4th and Maple. He had been nervous then, hands shaking, bun damp with sweat. He had taken fourteen packets of ketchup and a fistful of napkins. Nothing. But the rush of it, the way his heart had hammered against his chest as he ran, had been everything. He remembered standing two blocks away, laughing so hard he had nearly split down the middle. That was the night he understood who he was. The joy of stealing, of making others fear him. Growing up, he had always wanted to explore the wild west. He had wanted to be an outlaw, like the ones he saw in movies: whipping out his revolvers while on his horse and shooting a man dead in a duel. But he was not a bad man by heart.

He thought about what came after tomorrow. The plan had always been the horizon, the thing he was riding toward, and now it was close enough to touch. 900 million fries. The biggest score in food world history. His name on every poster, every broadcast, every whispered conversation in every diner and street corner from here to the coast. The most wanted food in all of the world. But would his mom be proud? She had never found out about his line of work. He had always lied, telling her he worked in accounting. Long hours, not much time to talk. He regretted not telling her the truth before she died. Would she be proud to call him her

son? Or was he just a scumbag: a scumbag who was still using the past to fuel his anger. A lowly criminal terrorizing the streets. Would she understand him? Would she understand why?